



Above Courtyard dining, North African *riadh*-style, at the Dar El Jeld restaurant in Tunis

Left Intricate tiling and stonework at the great mosque complex in Sidi Bou Saïd, a hilltop town a short metro train or taxi ride from the city



Above The crispy pastry of a *brik à l'oeuf* hides a secret: a golden egg yolk at its heart, waiting to burst at the first bite

What Else to Eat

Couscous, simply meaning “food,” was originally a staple of the nomadic North African Berber tribes. These granules of semolina are typically layered on herbs and cooked in the top half of a *kiskas*, or double boiler, above a spicy meat, fish, or vegetable stew, absorbing the aromas and flavors as it steams. While any ingredients can form the base – camel and octopus are Tunisian specialties – couscous is always enriched by herbs, spices, and harissa. One delicious version, known as **burzqan**, is mixed with fresh butter, mutton, saffron, and chickpeas, sprinkled with hot milk, and garnished with raisins, almonds, pistachios, hazelnuts, and walnuts.

The Best Places to Eat Brik à l’Oeuf

Dar El Jeld expensive

This atmospheric old place in the heart of the medina is one of the finest restaurants in Tunis. It’s in a beautiful 18th-century town house, and you might need some help to find it, but once through the flame-lit arched doorway and into the covered tiled courtyard that forms the dining area, you will experience everything that is magical and evocative about North Africa. By Tunisian standards this is an expensive place to eat, but it provides an unforgettable flavor of Tunis. The service is impeccably courteous, and reservations are essential. There is live music on most evenings. Several types of brik are available as appetizers, including a taster selection of mini-briks, and other specialties of the house include lamb couscous, an olive and beef stew, fish couscous, tajines, a North African-style paella, and an array of delicious pastry desserts. It is also the place to discover just how good Tunisian wines can be.

5–10 Rue Dar El Jeld, La Kasbah, Tunis; open for lunch and dinner Mon–Sat; closed for lunch in July and during Ramadan, and for all of August; www.dareljeld.tourism.tn

Also in Tunis

A venerable institution in the Souk El Trouk (the Turkish or tailors’ souk) in the medina, **M’rabet Café Restaurant (+216 71 561 729; inexpensive)** is the perfect place to take a break from the hectic bustle of the souks and relax with a coffee or a mint tea, or something more substantial. It has a café downstairs; upstairs is an inexpensive restaurant that serves brik alongside many other Tunisian specialties, including lamb and chicken couscous. Live music is often featured.

Also in Tunisia

Restaurant Chargui (+216 71 740 987; moderate) is one of the best restaurants in Sidi Bou Saïd, the picturesque little hilltop town close to Tunis. Open daily, it has a lovely blue- and white-washed terrace with great views over the sea, and its menu includes a choice of briks, a range of couscous dishes, and locally caught fresh grilled fish.

Around the World

An authentic taste of both Tunisia and Morocco can be found on Sutter Street in the heart of San Francisco at **Cafe Zitouna (www.cafezitouna.com; moderate)**, an unpretentious café/carry-out specializing in the flavors of North Africa. Brik is naturally on the menu, along with a wide range of tajines, couscous dishes, hot and spicy *merguez* sausages, and sticky baklava desserts.